is in the *Purana*s that much of what we today understand by popular Hinduism is anchored.

Not quite fitting into any of these categories is another magnificent work of early Hinduism, authored in the South by Thiruvalluvar (born around 300 CE) whose *Thirukkural*, a collection of 1,330 couplets or *kural*s containing profound aphorisms and imparting moral lessons, has been called by some 'the Veda of the Tamils'.

By the sixth century CE India and Hinduism had a rich mythology, a corpus of elaborate rites and rituals, extraordinary heroic poetry, a well-developed system of popular ethics, an evolving religious architecture and a spiritual literature for the masses. It also had non-religious texts of universal significance, notably the fables of the *Panchatantra*, which imparted practical advice on worldly matters (and on the foibles of human character) in the form of entertaining tales featuring both humans and animals. There is cynicism, including about kings and political leaders; violence, often unfortunate; and humour, sometimes at the expense of the vainglorious. 'We are told quite frankly,' observes the historian Upinder Singh, 'that conventional virtues can lead to ruin. Truthfulness, kindness, and helpfulness to others lead to disaster. The idea of self-sacrifice (even feigned) is mocked. Cunning, quick thinking, and hard-headedness are valorised. The only social relationship that is celebrated is friendship, and even that does not emerge unscathed.'[15]

With idol worship came temple construction, a feature of Hinduism only since the fifth century CE, and reaching its apogee in the magnificent Chola temples of the eleventh to the thirteenth centuries, many of which are still in use today. The 108 Agamas lay down the disciplines and doctrines for the worship of specific deities, notably Shiva, Vishnu and Shakti, which in turn have given birth to cults focused on each of these manifestations of the divine. They also specify the rules for constructing temples in honour of each of these, and for observing related rituals and rites. They are meticulously detailed, ranging from the ablutions to be performed by the worshipper to the adornments on the idol, the timing and order of prayers and so on, and also replete with devotional songs and verses. However, most people worship daily in the privacy of their own homes: instead of idols consecrated in temples, they